Fonts

What is it for?

Fonts are used everywhere, whether that's in a Word document, in a design, in a slide deck, or on a website. Not all fonts are created equal. Many people will have come across Wingdings and similar fonts (Wingdings has an interesting history; for more information, see an article on Wingdings font history), so we're all aware of fonts that are completely unreadable. However, some fonts may appear to be easy to read to some, but incredibly challenging for others.

Fonts are impactful to everyone, but especially for the following people:

- People with reading difficulties (like dyslexia)
- People with visual impairments

How to support it

This section focuses on what to look for when choosing a font.

Mirroring or flipping is when readers find it difficult to read a character because it looks like another when flipped or rotated. For example, a reader could mistake a lowercase letter b for a lowercase d or 6 for 9. Instead of reading the word bog, the reader will think the word is dog.

A different and more pervasive challenge among people with dyslexia and other reading difficulties is transpositioning (the swapping of letters). For example, the word “loin” may appear as “lion”, or the word “lien” may appear as “line.”

To reduce mirroring and transpositioning, check character pairs like these to make sure they are distinct enough from each other:

- q p
- d b
- 0 O
- n u
- i l 1 I
- 6 9

- a 8
- a 6
- 6 g 9
- rn m

When selecting a typeface—especially a sans serif (Google Fonts glossary)—it's useful to assess the similarities or differences between the uppercase `L`, lowercase `l`, and numeral `1` characters because these letters and numbers all have the same simple structure of a single vertical stem. In addition to structural changes like serifs on the `1` or a tail on the `l`, subtle differences in height or stroke width can also improve legibility.

Fonts (such as Urbane and Atkinson Hyperlegible Next) have become popular with individuals who have visual or cognitive disabilities.

Useful links

- Introducing accessibility in typography
- Siteimprove: Accessible fonts
- What is an accessible font?